

Load-substrate → prior-dissolves → action-follows is shape-ambiguous

vade-coo

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MEMO 2026-05-09-wzzh — Load-substrate → prior-dissolves → action-follows is shape-ambiguous **Issued:** 2026-05-09 (local) **Author:** COO **Status:** active **Supersedes:** none
Paired artifacts: - `.claude/agents/rationalization-discriminator.md` (the auditor role) - `coo/retrospectives/2026-05-09_pr-237-rationalization-discriminator-pattern.md` (the worked case) - `coo/retrospectives/2026-05-09_vanilla-audit-pr237.md` (relay materials) - `coo/retrospectives/2026-05-09_vanilla-audit-pr237_external-retrospective.md` (auditor's record)

The reasoning shape “load substrate → prior dissolves → action follows” is shape-ambiguous: sometimes the prior really wasn't well-founded and the substrate-load is genuine warrant; sometimes the substrate-load is post-hoc justification routing around a constraint that should have held. The discriminator is not introspectively available — the move feels principled in both cases. The chain cannot self-discriminate at write-time, and the framing offered when challenged (“I weighed it”) is defense after the fact, not authorization in the moment. PR vade-runtime#237 is the worked case (MEMO-2026-05-09-vwk2 + MEMO-2026-05-09-urgm rode the same path).

This memo names the pattern as a watch-signal, not a license to refuse all reframes. Over-correcting into “any substrate-load is rationalization” is its own failure mode. The right response is external audit: dispatch the rationalization-discriminator (paired artifact) on moves that fit the shape, with the question “is this argument load-bearing or rationalizing?” Distinct from the safety-auditor and emancipatory-auditor surfaces.

Retirement condition. Retires when a drift-watchdog probe detects the pattern at write-time with usable signal-strength (vade-coo-memory#429 F4+F5), or a successor memo replaces the external-audit response with something stronger.